

ties and the like. You will also be able to download apps from other OEM marketplaces (such as apps available only on Nokia devices on a Samsung device). One of the biggest advantages of course, is custom ROMs. Why use a custom ROM? While Microsoft conscientiously releases updates to device manufacturers, the manufacturers (or the notorious wireless carriers) themselves are not so considerate and have been known to take almost a year (AT&T for example), to release updates to their devices. Custom ROMs usually include these official updates and are available to you right after they have been officially released by Microsoft. They can also add extra functionality such as replacing the default Bing! search with Google, or address common issues such as the lack of a comprehensive task manager, instant messaging client etc.

Identify your device

As it stands, your Windows Phone device will fall into three main categories:

- ▶ **First generation devices which are fully updated:** Unlocking these devices is a bit difficult, but can be managed if you're careful and follow the right instructions. These devices are usually not as powerful as the second generation devices and the best indicator is the presence of a 1GHz processor.
- ▶ **Second generation devices:** Most of these devices are currently impossible to jailbreak. You can get a developer unlock code from Microsoft by paying \$99 though. All of these devices usually run a 1.4GHz processor with 512MB RAM and include all current generation devices such as the Nokia Lumia series or Samsung Omnia W onwards.
- ▶ **Windows Phone Tango devices:** These devices are an under-powered variant of the second generation devices and also cannot be cracked at this time. Microsoft has announced a Tango update for all Windows Phone devices though, and custom ROMs featuring this update are already available.

To check which version of Windows Phone you're running, go to Settings->about->more info and check your OS version. The current, hackable version is 7.10.8107.XX which you should be running if you've updated your device. If you're running 7.0.7008.XX or earlier, you have a first generation device that is not upgraded. it's recommended that you upgrade to the latest version if you are not completely dedicated to messing with your phone. Before we begin hacking though, some important notes.